

Functions in C

A function in C is a block of organized reusable code that performs a single related action. Every C program has at least one function, which is **main()**, and all the most trivial programs can define additional functions.

When the algorithm of a certain problem involves long and complex logic, it is broken into smaller, independent and reusable blocks. These small blocks of code are known by different names in different programming languages such as a **module**, a **subroutine**, a **function** or a **method**.

You can divide up your code into separate functions. How you divide up your code among different functions is up to you, but logically the division is such that each function performs a specific task.

A function **declaration** tells the compiler about a function's name, return type, and parameters. A function **definition** provides the actual body of the function.

The C standard library provides numerous built-in functions that your program can call. For example, **strcat()** to concatenate two strings, **memcpy()** to copy one memory location to another location, and many more functions.

Modular Programming in C

Functions are designed to perform a specific task that is a part of an entire process. This approach towards software development is called **modular programming**.

Modular programming takes a top-down approach towards software development. The programming solution has a main routine through which smaller independent modules (functions) are called upon.

Each function is a separate, complete and reusable software component. When called, a function performs a specified task and returns the control back to the calling routine, optionally along with result of its process.

The main advantage of this approach is that the code becomes easy to follow, develop and maintain.

Library Functions in C

C offers a number of **library functions** included in different **header files**. For example, the **stdio.h** header file includes **printf()** and **scanf()** functions. Similarly, the **math.h** header file includes a number of functions such as **sin()**, **pow()**, **sqrt()** and more.

These functions perform a predefined task and can be called upon in any program as per requirement. However, if you don't find a suitable library function to serve your purpose,

you can define one.

Explore our **latest online courses** and learn new skills at your own pace. Enroll and become a certified expert to boost your career.

Defining a Function in C

In C, it is necessary to provide the forward declaration of the prototype of any function. The prototype of a library function is present in the corresponding header file.

For a user-defined function, its prototype is present in the current program. The definition of a function and its prototype declaration should match.

After all the statements in a function are executed, the flow of the program returns to the calling environment. The function may return some data along with the flow control.

Function Declarations in C

A **function declaration** tells the compiler about a function name and how to call the function. The actual body of the function can be defined separately.

A function declaration has the following parts –

```
return_type function_name(parameter list);
```

For the above defined function max(), the function declaration is as follows –

```
int max(int num1, int num2);
```

Parameter names are not important in function declaration only their type is required, so the following is also a valid declaration –

```
int max(int, int);
```

A function declaration is required when you define a function in one source file and you call that function in another file. In such cases, you should declare the function at the top of the file calling the function.

Parts of a Function in C

The general form of a function definition in C programming language is as follows –

```
return_type function_name(parameter list){

    body of the function
}
```

A function definition in C programming consists of a function header and a function body. Here are all the parts of a function –

- **Return Type** – A function may return a value. The return_type is the data type of the value the function returns. Some functions perform the desired operations without returning a value. In this case, the return_type is the keyword void.
- **Function Name** – This is the actual name of the function. The function name and the parameter list together constitute the function signature.
- **Argument List** – An argument (also called parameter) is like a placeholder. When a function is invoked, you pass a value as a parameter. This value is referred to as the actual parameter or argument. The parameter list refers to the type, order, and number of the parameters of a function. Parameters are optional; that is, a function may contain no parameters.
- **Function Body** – The function body contains a collection of statements that defines what the function does.

A function in C should have a return type. The type of the variable returned by the function must be the return type of the function. In the above figure, the add() function returns an int type.

Example: User-defined Function in C

In this program, we have used a user-defined function called **max()**. This function takes two parameters **num1** and **num2** and returns the maximum value between the two –


[Open Compiler](#)

```
#include <stdio.h>

/* function returning the max between two numbers */
int max(int num1, int num2){

    /* local variable declaration */
    int result;
```

```

    if(num1 > num2)
        result = num1;
    else
        result = num2;

    return result;
}

int main(){
    printf("Comparing two numbers using max() function: \n");
    printf("Which of the two, 75 or 57, is greater than the other? \n");
    printf("The answer is: %d", max(75, 57));

    return 0;
}

```

Output

When you run this code, it will produce the following output –

```

Comparing two numbers using max() function:
Which of the two, 75 or 57, is greater than the other?
The answer is: 75

```

Calling a Function in C

While creating a C function, you give a definition of what the function has to do. To use a function, you will have to call that function to perform the defined task.

To call a function properly, you need to comply with the declaration of the function prototype. If the function is defined to receive a set of arguments, the same number and type of arguments must be passed.

When a function is defined with arguments, the arguments in front of the function name are called **formal arguments**. When a function is called, the arguments passed to it are the **actual arguments**.

When a program calls a function, the program control is transferred to the called function. A called function performs a defined task and when its return statement is executed or when its function-ending closing brace is reached, it returns the program control back to the main program.

Example: Calling a Function

To call a function, you simply need to pass the required parameters along with the function name. If the function returns a value, then you can store the returned value. Take a look at the following example –


[Open Compiler](#)

```
#include <stdio.h>

/* function declaration */
int max(int num1, int num2);

int main (){

    /* local variable definition */
    int a = 100;
    int b = 200;
    int ret;

    /* calling a function to get max value */
    ret = max(a, b);

    printf( "Max value is : %d\n", ret );

    return 0;
}

/* function returning the max between two numbers */
int max(int num1, int num2){

    /* local variable declaration */
    int result;

    if (num1 > num2)
        result = num1;
    else
        result = num2;

    return result;
}
```

Output

We have kept `max()` along with `main()` and compiled the source code. While running the final executable, it would produce the following result –

```
Max value is : 200
```

The main() Function in C

A C program is a collection of one or more functions, but one of the functions must be named as **main()**, which is the entry point of the execution of the program.

From inside the `main()` function, other functions are called. The `main()` function can call a library function such as `printf()`, whose prototype is fetched from the header file (`stdio.h`) or any other user-defined function present in the code.

In C, the order of definition of the program is not material. In a program, wherever there is `main()`, it is the entry point irrespective of whether it is the first function or not.

Note: In C, any function can call any other function, any number of times. A function can call itself too. Such a self-calling function is called a **recursive function**.

Function Arguments

If a function is to use arguments, it must declare variables that accept the values of the arguments. These variables are called the **formal parameters** of the function.

Formal parameters behave like other local variables inside the function and are created upon entry into the function and destroyed upon exit.

While calling a function, there are two ways in which arguments can be passed to a function –

Sr.No	Call Type & Description
1	Call by value This method copies the actual value of an argument into the formal parameter of the function. In this case, changes made to the parameter inside the function have no effect on the argument.
2	Call by reference This method copies the address of an argument into the formal parameter. Inside the function, the address is used to access the actual argument used in the call. This means that changes made to the parameter affect the argument.

By default, C uses **call by value** to pass arguments. In general, it means the code within a function cannot alter the arguments used to call the function.

User-defined Functions in C

A **function** in C is a block of organized, reusable code that is used to perform a single related action. In any C program, there are one or more functions – classified as library functions and user-defined functions.

There are two types of functions in C –

- Library functions
- User-defined functions

Any C compiler (e.g. GCC compiler, Clang, MSVC compiler, etc.) is distributed with a number precompiled header files (`stdio.h`, `math.h`, etc.), each consisting of one or more predefined library functions such as `printf()`, `scanf()`, `pow()`, `sqrt()`, etc. To be able to use the library function, the corresponding header file must be made available with the **#include** directive.

However, if you don't find a suitable library function to serve your purpose, then you can define a customized function for the program. Normally, we find a C program with a **main() function**. Obviously, the `main()` function is a user-defined function, as it contains the instructions provided by the user. It can of course call the other library or user-defined functions.

What is User-Defined Function in C?

User-defined function is defined by the user to perform specific task to achieve the code reusability and modularity. To create and use the user-defined function, you do not need use any built-in library. These functions can be created either in the same program or in user-defined header file.

Creating a User-defined Function

For creating a user-defined function, first you need to understand the purpose of the function, that is, what do you want the function to do?

To create a user-defined function, you need to know about the following three parts of a function:

- Function declaration
- Function definition
- Function calling

Declaration of User-defined Function

In C language, it is necessary to provide the declaration of the prototype of any function. The prototype of a library function is present in the corresponding header file.

For a user-defined function, its prototype is present in the current program. The definition of a function and its prototype declaration should match.

Syntax

If you wish to define a function called `add()` that performs the addition of two integer arguments and returns the value as an integer, then the function declaration would be as follows –

```
int add(int, int);
```

Definition of User-defined Function

The definition of a function and its prototype declaration should match. The definition consists of a function header that matches the declaration and a function body.

Syntax

```
return_type function_name(arg1, arg2, ...){  
  
    // Function body;  
  
    return val;  
  
}
```

Example

Using this template, you can write the user-defined function `add()` as follows –

```
int add(int a, int b){  
    int c;  
    c = a + b;  
    return c;  
}
```


Note that the order of definition of user-defined functions is not important in a C program. However, its prototype must be declared before calling the function.

In a program, the `main()` function is always the entry point, irrespective of whether it is the first function or not. We needn't provide the prototype declaration of the `main()` function.

Calling a User-defined Function

To call a function, you should use a statement that complies with the declaration of the function prototype. If the function is defined to receive a certain number of arguments, then the same number and type of arguments must be passed to call that function.

Example

The following statement calls the `add()` function that we defined above –

```
int result = add(10, 20);
```

Explore our **latest online courses** and learn new skills at your own pace. Enroll and become a certified expert to boost your career.

Example of User-Defined Function

In this example, we are create two user-defined functions **`add()`** and **`sub()`** to find the addition and subtraction of the given numbers.


[Open Compiler](#)

```
// C program to demonstrate an example of
// user-defined function
#include <stdio.h>

// Function declarations
int add(int, int);
int sub(int, int);

// Function definitions
int add(int a, int b) {
    return (a + b);
}

int sub(int a, int b) {
```

```

    return (a - b);
}

int main() {
    // Declaring two integer variables to
    // store the numbers
    // and resultant variables to store the result
    int num1 = 36, num2 = 24;
    int res_add, res_sub;

    // Calling the functions
    res_add = add(num1, num2);
    res_sub = sub(num1, num2);

    // Printing the results
    printf("Addition is : %d\n", res_add);
    printf("Subtraction is : %d\n", res_sub);

    return 0;
}

```

```

Addition is : 60
Subtraction is : 12

```

Formal and Actual Arguments in User-Defined Function

When a function is defined with arguments, the arguments in the parenthesis in front of the function name are called **formal arguments**. In the above example, the function is defined with "int a" and "int b" arguments; they are formal arguments.

When the function is called, the arguments passed to it are called the **actual arguments**. In the example below, the variables "x" and "y" are the actual arguments.

```

int x = 10, y = 20;
int result = add(x, y);

```

A user-defined function may be defined to have any type of variables as formal arguments. It includes primary types (int, float, char), array, pointer, or struct/union type variables.

A function should return a value to the calling environment. By default, the return type of a function is **int** type. However, it can return any data type – primary type, array, pointer, or a struct as well as a pointer. You can even define a function that returns a **void** type.

Example

If either the number or the type of actual and formal arguments or the return type as in the forward declaration of a function and its definition don't match, then the compiler reports an error.

Look at the example below –


[Open Compiler](#)

```
#include <stdio.h>

float divide (int, int);

int main(){

    int x = 15, y = 5;

    float z = divide (x, y);

    printf("%f", z);

    return 0;
}

int divide (int a, int b){

    int c = a/b;

    return c;
}
```

Output

In the code above, the declaration of the divide() function doesn't match with its definition, hence the compiler shows the following error –

error: conflicting types for 'divide'

In C, any function can call any other function, any number of times. A function can call itself too. Such a self-calling function is called a **recursive function**.

The following program calls the main() function from inside main() itself –

```
#include <stdio.h>

int main(){

    printf("Hello");

    main();

    return 0;
}
```

When executed, the program goes into an infinite loop. In practice, **recursion** has to be used so that the program eventually terminates.